

“Indian Wars 1872-1886” Prototype Concept



This map is currently incomplete and not public. Its name will probably be "Wild West: The Last Indian Wars" instead of "Indian Wars" to avoid confusion with the South Asian country. If the reader really wants a playable product the information in this document can easily be adapted to paper & pencil or tabletop miniatures.

USA UNITS

- Settlers Militia - Local armed civilian volunteers defending against Indian raids.
- US Infantry - U.S. Regular Army infantry armed with Springfield trapdoor rifles.
- US Cavalry - Mounted dragoons with 1873 carbines for rapid frontier pursuits.
- Scalp Bounty Hunters - Civilian contractors paid per scalp, armed with Sharps rifles and Bowie knives.
- US Heliograph Station - Using mirrors to reflect sunlight and flash coded signals across long distances, it enabled real-time tracking of small Indian bands.

NATIVE UNITS

- Indian Infantry - Foot soldiers armed with rifles, bows, and war clubs.
- Indian Cavalry - After the Spanish brought horses to the Americas, Native warriors quickly mastered riding, becoming swift and devastating mounted fighters.
- Comanche Warrior - Legendary mounted warriors of the Southern Plains known for their brutal raids for horses and captives against Whites and rival Indian tribes alike.
- Apache Guerrillas - Long range militia. Fierce irregular fighters who waged a relentless war against the United States.

THE IDEA: Major Indian Wars from the 1870s through the end of the **Apache Wars** (considered to end with Geronimo's surrender on **September 4, 1886**). Overall, it covers:

- 1) Modoc War (1872–1873):** A small but costly conflict in northern California/Oregon where a band of Modoc people under Captain Jack resisted forced relocation to a Klamath reservation. They held off a much larger U.S. Army force from a volcanic lava bed stronghold for months before being captured and executed.
- 2) Red River War (1874–1875):** Comanche and Kiowa bands fought and raided against United States. Major battles include Battle of Adobe Walls and Battle of Palo Duro Canyon.
- 3) Apache Wars (1879–1886)** A prolonged guerrilla conflict spanning New Mexico, Texas, Arizona, and northern Mexico, the Apache Wars represented the final and most enduring chapter of Native resistance in the American Southwest. Apache leaders exploited their intimate knowledge of the harsh desert and mountain terrain to strike swiftly and disappear before the army could respond, often retreating across the Mexican border where U.S. troops could not legally follow.

Part of the overall Apache Wars was Victorio's War (1879–1880), which saw the Warm Springs Apache leader launch devastating raids across New Mexico and Texas, defeating multiple army detachments and evading capture for over a year. Unable to pin him down, U.S. forces coordinated with Mexican troops, who cornered and killed Victorio at Tres Castillos, Chihuahua in 1880. Nana's Raid (1881) followed shortly after. Despite being in his seventies and crippled, the Apache leader Nana led a band of fewer than 40 warriors on a sweeping raid across southern New Mexico, and escaping back into Mexico. Geronimo's Campaign (1881–1886) proved the most drawn-out and costly phase of the Apache Wars. He launched raids across Arizona, New Mexico, and northern Mexico before vanishing back into the Sierra Madre. From these remote hideouts they launched cross-border raids into American and Mexican settlements alike, with the populations of Sonora and Chihuahua suffering some of the heaviest losses of the entire war. U.S. forces repeatedly struggled to dislodge them, as the terrain was as formidable an enemy as the Apache themselves.

Interestingly, **scalp bounties** were offered by Mexican states (Chihuahua, Sonora) and sometimes Texas, attracting American mercenaries like the notorious James Kirker, who led mixed groups hunting Apache scalps for payment.

The next page covers event messages, spanning Summer 1872 to Winter 1886. There are two seasons per year, summer & winter. The Black Hawk, Bannock and Sioux Wars are mentioned in event messages only as background context, and will not be featured in the final map.

TURN EVENT MESSAGES:

Turn 1: Summer 1872. Since long before the United States existed, Native tribes and European colonists clashed over land and resources, even as tribes warred among themselves for territory and dominance. By the 1870s, centuries of conflict and westward expansion had brought a final chapter of significant Native violence against settlers. Throughout the entire Southwest, the U.S. Army is responding to crush resistance and confine the Indian tribes to reservations for good.

Turn 2: Winter 1872. In Utah Territory, pressure from the United States Army has ended Ute resistance to Mormon settlement of that region, ending the Black Hawk War. In California, the Modoc War begins when the U.S. tries to force the Modoc people onto an Oregon reservation shared with their traditional enemies, the Klamath.

Turn 3: Summer 1873. The Modoc War continues.

Turn 4: Winter 1873. General Canby is killed during peace talks, ending any chance of a peaceful resolution. The Modoc War ends soon after with holdouts giving up. Modoc leaders are executed.

Turn 5: Summer 1874. The Red River War begins because of Southern Plains tribes' frustrations with the illegal poaching of buffalo by white hunters and overall failures of promised supply deliveries.

Turn 6: Winter 1874. General Sheridan leads the U.S. Army's campaign during the Red River War.

Turn 7: Summer 1875. The Red River War ends as starving bands of Comanche, Kiowa, and others surrender.

Turn 8: Winter 1875. Gold is discovered in the Black Hills of the Dakota Territory.

Turn 9: Summer 1876. The Great Sioux War erupts in the Dakota/Montana region.

Turn 10: Winter 1876. Humiliated by Custer's defeat at Little Bighorn, the U.S. Army launches a relentless winter campaign against the Sioux.

Turn 11: Summer 1877. The Great Sioux War ends with Sioux and Cheyenne leaders surrendering.

Turn 12: Winter 1877.

Turn 13: Summer 1878. Scattered fighting is occurring in Idaho territory between the Bannock tribe and U.S. Army forces.

Turn 14: Winter 1878.

Turn 15: Summer 1879. Victorio leads renewed Apache resistance across New Mexico and Texas.

Turn 16: Winter 1879.

Turn 17: Summer 1880. Victorio is killed at Tres Castillos, ending his campaign.

Turn 18: Winter 1880. Apache resistance continues.

Turn 19: Summer 1881. Nana leads a remarkable raid across the Southwest.

Turn 20: Winter 1881. Geronimo emerges as a key leader of Apache resistance.

Turn 21: Summer 1882.

Turn 22: Winter 1882.

Turn 23: Summer 1883.

Turn 24: Winter 1883.

Turn 25: Summer 1884.

Turn 26: Winter 1884.

Turn 27: Summer 1885. Geronimo escapes again, launching new raids across the Southwest.

Turn 28: Winter 1885. U.S. forces intensify their pursuit of Apache bands.

Turn 29: Summer 1886.

Turn 30: Winter 1886. Geronimo has officially surrendered to U.S. General Nelson A. Miles at Skeleton Canyon, Arizona on September 4th of this year. His surrender marked the end of major Apache resistance in the Southwest and concluded the Indian Wars.

Bonus Timeline of Native Conflict in the United States, 1675-1868

King Philip's War (1675-1678): New England colonists fought the Wampanoag under Metacom, known as King Philip, who were joined by the Narragansett, Nipmuc, and other allied bands, after years of land loss, pressure to convert to Christianity, and the killing of John Sassamon. The war began near Swansea in June 1675, and towns burned across Massachusetts, Plymouth, Rhode Island, and Connecticut. In December 1675 the Great Swamp Fight destroyed a Narragansett winter camp. Metacom was killed in August 1676, and many captives were hanged or sold into slavery. Fighting with the Abenaki continued in Maine until 1678. By the war's end, Native power in southern New England was broken, and relative to colonial population it was one of the deadliest wars in American history.

French and Indian War (1754-1763): Britain and France fought for control of the Ohio Country and Canada in what became known as the French and Indian War, part of the broader Seven Years' War. Native nations chose sides or tried to stay neutral between both powers. The Iroquois Confederacy leaned British, while many Algonquian nations in the Great Lakes and Ohio Valley leaned French. Fort William Henry fell to French and Native forces in 1757, and British General James Wolfe took Quebec in 1759, securing the war's decisive victory. France lost Canada to Britain in the 1763 Treaty of Paris that ended the war. James Fenimore Cooper's novel *The Last of the Mohicans* (1826) is set during this conflict, centered on the 1757 Lake George campaign.

Pontiac's War (1763-1766): After the French withdrew, British posts occupied Native land while offering fewer gifts and tolerating a growing number of squatters. In 1763, the Ottawa leader Pontiac led an uprising joined by the Ojibwe, Potawatomi, Huron, Delaware, Shawnee, and other nations. Detroit was besieged, and Michilimackinac and several smaller forts fell to the attackers. Colonel Henry Bouquet fought his way through to relieve Fort Pitt at the Battle of Bushy Run. The

uprising, later known as Pontiac's War, did not drive the British out, and peace was negotiated gradually over the following years. In response, the Proclamation of 1763 barred colonial settlement west of the Appalachian Mountains and reserved that interior land for Native nations under the Crown, but settlers crossed the line anyway.

Northwest Indian War / Little Turtle's War (1785-1795): The Miami, Shawnee, Delaware, and other allied nations fought the United States for the Ohio Country, defeating General Josiah Harmar in 1790 and then, on 4 November 1791, destroying Arthur St. Clair's army and killing about 600 soldiers, the worst defeat the United States ever suffered against Native forces until Little Bighorn. In response, Washington sent Anthony Wayne, a Revolutionary War general, who built a new disciplined force, advanced slowly while constructing forts and a supply road, and defeated the confederacy at Fallen Timbers on 20 August 1794 before burning their villages and crops. The resulting Treaty of Greenville (1795) ceded most of what is now Ohio south and east of a surveyed line to the United States, provided annuities, and left a reduced hunting territory to the northwest, but that line did not hold.

Tecumseh's Confederacy and the War of 1812 Indian theater (1808-1813): The Shawnee brothers Tecumseh and Tenskwatawa, known as the Prophet, built a confederacy to stop any single tribe from selling land to the United States. Its center was Prophetstown on the Tippecanoe River, and its call reached the Great Lakes, the Ohio Valley, and south toward the Creek. The rule was simple: the land was held in common and could not be signed away in pieces. While Tecumseh was away recruiting, William Henry Harrison burned Prophetstown on 7 November 1811 at the Battle of Tippecanoe. The next year the United States declared war on Britain, in part over British support for Native resistance on the frontier. Tecumseh joined the British in this War of 1812, helped take Detroit, and was killed on 5 October 1813 at the Thames in present-day Ontario. The confederacy did not survive him.

Creek War (1813-1814): The Creek Nation split into two factions during the Creek War. The Red Sticks, some of whom had been in contact with Tecumseh's confederacy, fought against the United States, Tennessee militia under Andrew Jackson, and allied Lower Creeks who sided with the Americans. Red Stick forces overran Fort Mims on 30 August 1813, killing hundreds of settlers and allied Creeks. Jackson broke the main Red Stick force at the Battle of Horseshoe Bend on 27 March 1814. The resulting Treaty of Fort Jackson seized about 23 million acres in present-day Alabama and Georgia, taking land even from the Lower Creeks who had fought alongside Jackson.

First Seminole War (1817-1818): Andrew Jackson, the general who had defeated the Red Sticks at Horseshoe Bend during the Creek War, invaded Spanish Florida after cross-border raids by Seminole warriors, in what became known as the First Seminole War. His targets were Seminole towns and communities of escaped slaves, following the earlier destruction of Negro Fort on the Apalachicola River the year before. During the invasion, Jackson had two British subjects, Alexander Arbuthnot and Robert Ambrister, executed for aiding the Seminoles. Spain proved unable to defend or control the province, and the resulting Adams-Onís Treaty of 1819 forced Spain to cede Florida to the United States. Jackson would not become president for another decade, elected in 1828 and inaugurated in 1829.

Indian Removal and the Trail of Tears (1830-1839): The Indian Removal Act (1830) gave the president power to swap eastern land for land west of the Mississippi. Choctaw, Chickasaw, Creek, Cherokee, and Seminole were the main targets. The Treaty of New Echota (1835) was signed by a Cherokee minority and used as the removal paper. In 1838-39 the army forced the Cherokee west. About 16,000 were marched. Several thousand died of cold, hunger, and disease on the Trail of Tears. The Creek, Choctaw, and Chickasaw were removed west in the same decade, and each march killed thousands more.

Black Hawk War (1832): Black Hawk was a Sauk war leader based in Illinois who rejected the validity of an 1804 treaty that had ceded Sauk and Fox land to the United States, believing it had been signed without proper tribal authority. He and the Sauk and Fox under his leadership recrossed the Mississippi River to plant crops on old village land near Rock Island, Illinois, defying that disputed cession. Illinois militia and U.S. regulars pursued them into Wisconsin, and the militia was routed early in the conflict at Stillman's Run. The war ended at the Battle of Bad Axe on 2 August 1832, where many were killed on the riverbank, including women and children. The Black Hawk War was short and one-sided, the last major conflict between the United States and Native nations east of the Mississippi. Black Hawk was taken east and displayed as a prisoner before his release in 1833, after which he settled with his family in Iowa and dictated his life story to an interpreter, publishing it that year as the first Native American autobiography printed in the United States. It became widely read at the time. Black Hawk died in Iowa in 1838.

Second Seminole War (1835-1842): The longest and costliest of the Seminole Wars. Osceola, Micanopy, Alligator, Wildcat, and other leaders refused to honor the Treaty of Payne's Landing, which had bound the Seminole to leave Florida for land in the west. On 28 December 1835 Seminole warriors destroyed a column of U.S. troops under Major Francis Dade, and the army then spent years fighting through Florida's hammocks and swamps. Osceola was seized under a white flag of truce in 1837 and died in captivity at Fort Moultrie in 1838. Most Seminoles were eventually shipped west, though a remnant held out in the Everglades. U.S. military deaths ran over 1,500. Unlike the other southeastern nations, the Seminole were never fully removed, and a population remained in Florida that never signed away claim to the peninsula.

Third Seminole War (1855-1858): The last Florida campaign. Billy Bowlegs led a small remaining Seminole population in resisting land surveys and encroaching squatters. U.S. forces

burned Seminole camps and offered cash payments to induce removal. Bowlegs and most of his followers went west in 1858, but a few families stayed hidden in Florida, escaping removal entirely.

Navajo Wars and the Long Walk (1860-1864): The United States claimed Navajo (Dine) country in present-day Arizona and New Mexico after the war with Mexico. Years of raids, broken agreements, new army posts, and encroaching miners brought on a full military campaign. In 1863 and 1864 Kit Carson led a scorched earth campaign, destroying fields, peach orchards, hogans, and livestock, and driving the Navajo into Canyon de Chelly. Most eventually surrendered. Survivors were then forced to walk roughly 300 to 400 miles to Bosque Redondo at Fort Sumner in what became known as the Long Walk. Thousands died along the way or in the camp itself from hunger, dysentery, cold, and raids by other tribes. Conditions at Bosque Redondo stayed harsh for years, with failed crops and bad water keeping the reservation barely livable. The 1868 treaty finally allowed survivors to leave and return to a reduced reservation on their own homeland.

Dakota War / Sioux Uprising (1862): The Eastern Dakota, or Santee, in Minnesota rose up in 1862 after late annuities, trader fraud, and a failed harvest. Killings at Acton on 17 August opened the conflict. Little Crow took command reluctantly, and Dakota forces attacked New Ulm and Fort Ridgely before the army defeated them at Wood Lake on 23 September. Little Crow fled, later returned, and was shot near Hutchinson in July 1863; settlers claimed a bounty and displayed his scalp and skull. Shakopee and Medicine Bottle were captured in Canada and hanged at Fort Snelling in 1865. A military commission condemned 303 Dakota men after brief trials, but Lincoln cut the list, and on 26 December 1862, 38 Dakota men were hanged at Mankato, still the largest mass execution in U.S. history. The government voided its treaties, seized remaining Dakota land, and expelled most of the tribe to Crow Creek, while many noncombatants had already died that winter in a prison camp at Fort Snelling.

Red Cloud's War (1866-1868): The Lakota, Northern Cheyenne, and Arapaho fought the United States for the Powder River hunting grounds and the string of forts protecting the Bozeman Trail, including Fort Reno, Fort Phil Kearny, and Fort C.F. Smith, in a conflict known as Red Cloud's War. On 21 December 1866, the Fetterman Fight killed all 81 soldiers sent out from Fort Phil Kearny. The Wagon Box and Hayfield fights in 1867 then showed the deadly effectiveness of Army breechloading rifles, but even that firepower could not keep the road open. The forts were abandoned, and the Treaty of Fort Laramie in 1868 closed the Bozeman Trail, ordered the remaining forts destroyed, and recognized the Great Sioux Reservation, including the Black Hills, as Lakota territory. It stands as one of the rare instances of a decisive Native strategic victory over the United States.

Legacy – To the Present day: Geronimo's surrender to Nelson A. Miles at Skeleton Canyon, Arizona, on 4 September 1886 marked the end of the last major Indian war in the United States. The promise of a short exile and a return home was not kept. He and other Chiricahua, including army scouts, were held as prisoners of war: Florida (Fort Pickens and Fort Marion), then Mount Vernon Barracks in Alabama, then Fort Sill in 1894. Heat and disease killed many. Children sent to Carlisle died in large numbers. Geronimo farmed, sold photographs, appeared under guard at the 1904 World's Fair and Roosevelt's 1905 parade, asked to go home, and was refused. He died at Fort Sill on 17 February 1909, still a POW, and is buried there. Chiricahua POW status ended in 1913. After 1886 the United States broke reservations through the Dawes Act, killed hundreds of Lakota at Wounded Knee in 1890, made Native people citizens in 1924, and later tried to dissolve tribes. In the 1960s and 1970s Native organizers seized Alcatraz, marched on Washington, and occupied Wounded Knee again to force the government to deal with broken treaties and reservation poverty. There are 574 federally recognized tribes. Most Native people now live off reservation.